

Health and Economic Returns to Dietary Sodium Reduction: Follow-up Discussion

Uncertainty types and a value-of-information frame for the source-of-sodium decision

Resolve to Save Lives (RTSL) – UW

June 2026

Follow-up Discussion

Recap: Where We Landed Last Time

Agreed:

- LSSS in via potassium supplementation; focus scenarios **4, 5** (discretionary-only).
- Do **not** map interventions to SHAKE pillars — the revamped SHAKE no longer frames them that way.
- Counterfactual (prevention) framing > pure lives-maximization (e.g. Ethiopia packaged-food policy kept despite low consumption).
- Primary deliverable is the **BP-reinvestment proposal** (Sep 2026), not the paper.

The unresolved blocker (Pending #4)

Source-of-sodium shares are **missing or low-quality** for most of the 29+ countries. The combined approach — country data where available, Bhat/Marklund GDP regression elsewhere — leaves open: *how hard do we push for better data?* RTSL is wary (past difficulty estimating sodium sources); Laura notes GDP misses condiment/bouillon-heavy contexts (Vietnam, Nigeria).

Today: reframe this from an opinion debate into a quantity we can estimate.

Why This Particular Gap Bites

The source split is not a side input — it is the **router** that decides which intervention touches which sodium, so error propagates straight into lives saved and into the BCR.

- Each lever acts on **one** source (FOPL/targets/tax → packaged; procurement → institutional; LSSS/media → discretionary).
- A wrong discretionary-vs-packaged split **re-weights the entire portfolio**, not one cell.
- GDP regression is a **point predictor with floors** (10% discret. USA, 2% packaged Ethiopia) — it carries prediction error we currently ignore.
- Shares are **time-sensitive** and packaged share is **growing** (Vandevijvere); a stale share biases the 2026–2050 trajectory, not just the base year.

So the question “country data vs. regression” is really: **is the decision (which policy mix to fund) sensitive to how wrong the share is?** That is a value-of-information question.